
15. Are you finding it almost impossible to get approval or “buy-in” on projects?

Think back. A long time ago, people would green-light your projects faster than the Road Runner on amphetamines. But that’s no longer the case. The boss is suddenly silent when it comes to approval. You’re being passed around from middle manager to middle manager. You get voicemail 99% of the time you call someone for an opinion, and the other 1% it’s their secretary . . . who then puts you through to voicemail. No one is going to green-light a project from someone whose time is up at that company. They don’t want to associate themselves with the kiss of death that is your idea. If it happens to be a great idea, no worries—they’ll take credit for it once you’re gone. The silent treatment is a sure sign of pink-slip disease.

16. Have you recently been asked to work on a “special project”?

This could have many other names. “New company initiative” or “Confidential research assignment” are other known terms for this. But it basically comes down to one role: The project

takes you away from *real* work and puts you on something that’s either mildly important, not important at all, is going nowhere, or is just plain useless.

“Hey, Smith, how is that special project on frozen concentrated orange juice coming along?”

“Fine, sir. Can I ask what this has to do with the IT department?”

“Oh, you’ll find out, Smith. You’ll find out.”

Rule of thumb: The second you are asked to leave a project you know is important for one that sounds like a bunch of bologna, your career is heading south quickly.

17. Are your successes and accomplishments being glossed over?

This one’s tricky to work out, because most bosses and coworkers are weasels who will happily play down your role in order to make themselves look good. But, judge this one by looking to the past. Did your boss used to praise you up to management? Were you a golden boy or girl? That’s great. But if it’s now impossible to get praise for doing something spectacular, like doubling company profits, then you’re being disrespected and probably have a large FIRE ME target printed on your forehead. If you’re not getting kudos, you may be getting fired.